Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, or Copilot?

More alike than different. Here is what is under the hood, and which fits your subject.

One technology

Each is a **large language model** that predicts the next word. It writes smoothly, and it can sound sure and still be wrong.

Free vs. paid

Free plans mostly get **faster, smaller** models. Paying buys the **strongest model** and higher limits.

Thinking mode

It **works step by step** before answering. Slower, but better for math and grading. All four have one.

Privacy setting

Personal accounts may **train the AI on your chats** unless you turn that off. School versions usually don't.

	Claude	ChatGPT	Gemini	Copilot
Website	claude.ai	chatgpt.com	gemini.google.com	m365copilot.com CAU sign-in
Free version gives you	Everyday version	Everyday version	Lightest version	With school accounts Ask CAU IT
Paying adds	Strongest version Pro: $20/month	Strongest version Go, Plus, or Pro	Strongest version $19.99/month	Word and Excel School buys it
Makes pictures	No Charts and diagrams	Yes	Yes	Yes
Research reports	Paid plan	Yes	Yes, even free	Paid license
Your chats train it?	Your choice Settings, Privacy	Yes, unless off Settings, Data controls	Yes, if Activity is on Reviewers may read	No, with CAU sign-in

Which fits your subject?

Math and sciences

Any of the four. Turn on the thinking option and add "Double-check the arithmetic." Check every step.

Writing-heavy courses

Any of the four. Try the same prompt in two and keep the voice you like.

Research and current events

Use a research report or web search. Open every source; AI can cite pages that don't say what it claims.

Long documents

Paid versions read far more at once. On a free plan, split long files into parts.

Pictures for slides

ChatGPT, Gemini, or Copilot. Check science images closely; labels often come out wrong.

Anything about students

Only a tool CAU approves. Copilot with your CAU login may qualify. Ask IT first.

Just starting? Pick one, turn off the setting that trains on your chats, and try it on your own course materials. When the stakes are high, ask a second one too.